eye off the COVID-19 fight. In retrospect, to be fair, the EC should have postponed polls during a sniggering wave of the pandemic. And if it did go ahead with the polls, with meticulous planning for crowd management, it should have set stringent restrictions in place for campaigning and rallies which *all* parties should have adhered to. But, the speed at which cases rose, it was also difficult for anyone to predict the extent of cases. Also if elections were postponed, would President's rule have been accepted by all parties in all poll-bound states? All parties, in the spirit of Indian unity, should have suspended physical rallies, keeping in mind that it was still *us* against the *virus* and not *you* against *me*. However, in a deeply fractured political atmosphere, where it was unimaginable to have competitors sit across the table and take decisions in the larger interest of the nation, this was an unrealistic expectation to have!

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11 MARCH 2021

INDIA | 1,99,273 ACTIVE CASES | 1,59,454 DEATHS | 2.10 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 1,43,40,314 ACTIVE CASES | 27,60,017 DEATHS | 20.62 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

Meanwhile, almost simultaneously, in Haridwar (Uttarakhand), the Kumbha Mela was scheduled to be held through the months of March and April. The Kumbha Mela is the largest religious gathering on earth which takes place every 12 years in sync with every full revolution of the planet Jupiter (Brihaspati in Indian astrology). It is held to celebrate the Hindu myth of *samudra manthan*—the churning of the cosmological ocean by the gods and demons to secure *amrit*, the nectar of immortality. The congregation is marked by four main holy dips (Shahi Snan), which take place through the duration of the mela, along with a celebratory gathering and discourses by saints. The holy dips are considered as soul-cleansing exercises for Hindu seers, a path to absolve one of past sins. The congregation, apart from being attended by Hindu pilgrims from across India and the world, is also attended by sadhus (saints) who belong to the 10 monastic orders called *akharas*. These seers live in remote caves and only step out for the Kumbha Mela, which is usually held on a rotational basis, every three years in four